

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Downed wires & electrical hazards

HOME BUILDING / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Keep away from fallen wires, damaged electrical equipment and anything touching them, including water, fences and vehicles. Assume wires are live even when they are quiet or the neighbourhood has no power. Do not attempt a rescue by touching a person or object in contact with electricity. Contact the utility or emergency services from a safe place.

Do now.

- ☐ **Stay back**
01 Do not approach to determine whether a wire is live. Current can travel through wet ground and conductive objects. Keep others and animals away.
- ☐ **Avoid connected objects**
02 Do not touch fences, trees, vehicles or debris that may contact a wire. Do not use a stick or tool to move it.
- ☐ **Stay out of flooded electrical areas**
03 Never enter water to reach a breaker, appliance or person near damaged electrical systems. Use qualified help.
- ☐ **Warn from safety**
04 Tell people to avoid the area from your safe location. Report a clear location without approaching for a photograph.
- ☐ **Do not restore damaged systems**
05 Leave flooded, scorched or broken equipment off until qualified personnel assess it. A restored grid does not make damaged wiring safe.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Keep the hazard avoided if the utility cannot be reached. Do not move a wire to open a road or restore access; arrange a different safe route.

Watch for.

Do not assume a fixed visible distance proves safety. Lines may reenergise without warning; no spark or hum is not an all-clear.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group

Next decision.

If a wire falls onto a vehicle you occupy, generally stay inside and call for help; fire or another immediate threat changes the decision. Follow qualified emergency instructions rather than touching the vehicle and ground together.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

CDC · [Protect yourself during a power outage](#)

CDC · [Avoid carbon monoxide poisoning](#)

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/downed-power-lines/>